former COAS, who had undergone a major surgery a few days earlier. He was quite unwell and still recuperating. When he came to know that we were to visit, he made it a point to freshen up and get dressed. When we entered his room, not heeding my protestations, he stood up and saluted, saying that when the Chief comes, you have to stand to attention. I was deeply touched and at the same time proud of the strong traditions that we have. Later, Anupama Singh, his wife, told us that it was the first time that he had got out of bed since the operation and that our visit had invigorated him and put him on the road to recovery. If the visit of the Chief can have such a positive effect on a former Chief, I can only hope that it had a similar effect on the other patients. Incidentally, Anupama Singh's father was also posted at the Embassy in France, at about the same time that we were there; she and my sister were great friends, and she remembers my brother and me as the annoying young kids who would always be troubling them.

January is a busy month, full of ceremonial events. There is the Army Day, followed by the Republic Day Parade at Kartavya Path (Raj Path) and the Beating Retreat Ceremony at Vijay Chowk. There is also Martyrs' Day in remembrance of Mahatma Gandhi at his Samadhi at Raj Ghat. Assuming office in January had its own challenges, which included getting to grips with the job while at the same time, monitoring these ceremonial events, in which the Army has a major role to play. But first, I decided to address the Principal Staff Officers and the key appointments posted in the Integrated HQ of the MoD (Army) or more colloquially, the Army HQ. I felt that they should hear their Chief first-hand and get to know me, and through them, I hoped that my message would percolate down to the rank and file. The key point I made, through my experience in command of 2 RR (SIKH LI), was that I was the

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